

MacBook Pro Recovery and macOS Update with Apple ID

🖥️ Device:

- **Model:** MacBook Pro Retina 15" (A1398)
- **Original Operating System:** macOS Big Sur
- **Initial Situation:** The device owner, Gladys Mayen, didn't remember the password, and the Mac hadn't been used or updated in years.



Security Explanation

The computer has a security feature called File Vault.

This means all contents are **encrypted** and can only be unlocked with the correct password or Apple ID. It's like a digital safe.

In addition, the Mac is linked to an **Apple ID** account, which is the same used for iCloud, App Store, etc.”

“If the Apple ID is forgotten, it can be recovered here:

✓ <https://iforgot.apple.com>

But if it cannot be recovered, the Mac remains permanently locked.

Step 1: Initial Diagnosis

- Upon startup, the Mac displayed the login screen with her name.
- The password was forgotten.

A message was shown:

"If you're having a problem entering your password..."

Step 2: Entering Recovery Mode

- I shut down the Mac completely.
- Pressed **Cmd (⌘) + R** on startup to access **macOS Recovery**.

Wi-Fi Connection and Protection Verification

Before proceeding, I made sure the Mac was connected to the internet, which is essential for Apple ID verification.

- On the **macOS Utilities** screen, I clicked the **Wi-Fi icon** at the top-right corner.
- Selected the available network and entered the Wi-Fi password to connect.

Step 3: Protection Verification and Unlocking

- Instead of using Terminal, the system showed Gladys' profile directly.
- I selected her user account, and the option to enter her **Apple ID** appeared.

Authentication Steps:

- Entered her Apple ID email and password.
- Apple sent a **verification code to her iPhone**.
- We entered the code successfully, and the system **unlocked the Mac**.
- It prompted to create a new password, which I set to something simple and easy for her to remember.

No Terminal or command-line tools were necessary.

Step 4: System Login and Access

- I restarted the Mac from the menu.
- On the login screen, I entered the **new password**.

- Login was successful.

Step 5: System Status Check

Before returning the Mac, I proceeded to update the operating system.

Available Disk Space Verification:

- Clicked on > About This Mac > Storage.
- Confirmed there was over 20 GB of free space available for the update.

Step 6: Operating System Update

- Opened > System Preferences > Software Update.
- The Mac searched for available updates.
- A newer version of macOS was found.
- Clicked on “Update Now”.
- The Mac downloaded and installed the updates, including: Updated Safari
 - Security patches
 - System stability improvements

Lessons Learned

- I learned that macOS offers a guided recovery option if the Apple ID is active.
- Practiced a secure, ethical, and legal recovery process.
- Successfully explained every step in plain language to an older adult.
- Performed basic preventive maintenance (disk check, storage check, and OS update).

Final Result

- The Mac is now accessible, functional, and updated.
- Gladys regained full control of her device and can easily change her password in the future.

References:

Apple ID recovery: <https://iforgot.apple.com>

Apple’s official password recovery guide: <https://support.apple.com/en-us/102673>